

Windows is undoubtedly the most popular operating system you will find on personal computers, and as such, Microsoft Visual Studio remains a popular choice as a programming environment. The Microsoft .NET SDK is used to build applications in the recent Visual Studio products:

.NET

.NET isn't a programming language, instead there are multiple programming languages which can be used to build .NET applications. Much like Java, .NET applications are compiled to bytecode which Microsoft calls the Common Intermediate Language (CIL) which is then run by the .NET Common Language Runtime (CLR). Many of Microsoft's technologies can use .NET as their programming system, so learning a .NET language means that you can write for any platform which is .NET capable. Microsoft Silverlight and ASP.NET are examples for web technologies which utilise .NET. While this is a Windows technology, the open source community is hard at work on the Mono framework, which will enable .NET applications to be written for Linux-like operating systems.

Computers have become much more powerful now than we could have imagined a few years ago, and this has also led to a change in how people develop applications. We are not talking about applications becoming larger, or having more visual effects, but about the way application are run or compiled. The abundance of computing power has led to the rise of interpreted languages such as Ruby, Python, Perl, and the overhead they consume is no longer that significant. Python and Perl are both very popular for writing scripts for the *NIX environment.

It is impossible to list all the languages you can use to write desktop applications or even those which you might need to develop in. On one hand, you can learn popular languages to make you suitable for a large number of jobs, and on the other hand, by learning some of the less

ACHIEVING UBIQUITY

The reason most people cite for avoiding operating systems such as Linux is the lack of their favourite applications outside of Windows.

There is a vicious loop we see, where software companies avoid creating software for Linux due to the increased cost in supporting an additional platform, while people avoid the platform due to the lack of software on it!

There are many projects now that aim to break this cycle, by improving cross platform compatibility of applications.

Linux users will be familiar with WINE (WINE is not an emulator) which allows you to run Windows applications on Linux. Thanks to WINE, some of the people who have been held back due to their dependence on Windows-only software can now switch to Linux.

popular languages, you gain an edge over the mainstream developers. For example, by learning some of the older languages such as FORTRAN and COBOL you can be of immense use to organisations which need to deal with applications written in such code in the past.

Developing... web applications

When it comes to web development, there are no choices more obvious than HTML and JavaScript. Surely you can start off there, but gone are the days of web pages with static content. To unleash the full power of the internet you need to make websites dynamic

The number of desktop programming languages is so diverse that it is impossible to learn them all

in body, mind and spirit.

To call yourself a web developer you need to not only know HTML and JavaScript but also at least one server-side programming language, extra cookies for those who know more.

For web development, you need to know the languages of the web:

Nokia's Qt toolkit (formerly owned by Trolltech) is another solution that works the other way around. The Qt toolkit allows developers to write software once which can then be compiled for Windows, Linux or MacOS, and even manages to ensure that each user gets their native UI experience.

If you intend to develop applications that need to run on all platforms, you can benefit greatly from learning about such solutions. Even if you do not intend to use Qt for developing your application, it is wise to at least ensure that your application runs properly on Linux using Wine.

Such solutions can greatly ease a developers task. In fact, the Linux version of Google's popular image management software Picasa, has been created using WINE, thereby nearly eliminating the effort of porting the application.

HTML

The web is HTML. Whatever goes on in the back-end is irrelevant to the user, as all they will see is what the final HTML code renders. You have to start web development by learning HTML, and no, knowing how to use a WYSIWYG editor like Dreamweaver won't do.

CSS

CSS, HTML's sister language is about as important for a web developer today. While HTML gives you the raw data and layout of the web-page, it is CSS which gives it style, and grace.

JavaScript

The magic potion which makes a website come alive. To engage the user in a true interaction with the website, you need to use JavaScript, without it you; web page is exactly dead.

A static website is a stagnant website. Unless all you need to do is showcase pictures of your cats, you need to know at least one server-side language to make your website worthwhile. Some of the most important tools are:



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AND WIN.

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